Curzon's appointment as viceroy is telling: 'He goes as knowing something of India...but some might say that he knows too much and that he must have a great deal to unlearn.'[109] However, Curzon was not by nature a man open to having his opinions challenged. Indeed, his time spent as ruler of India appears only to have strengthened his convictions in regards to the importance of the Raj to Britain, and of the inherent threat to it posed by Russia. Curzon's inexhaustible capacity for work, combined with his belief that the best defence was offence when it came to Russia, meant that he never relented in pushing for an activist British policy in Asia.

When it came to Persia, for example, the viceroy was highly vocal in his criticism of the Home government's apparent apathy towards that country. Curzon found the attitude of Lord Salisbury and his adherence to the policy of 'splendid isolation' particularly frustrating.[110] In his desire to see a stronger British hand in Persia, Curzon would also often clash with the British minister to Tehran, Sir Arthur Hardinge.[111] While the viceroy was continually criticising Hardinge for apparently failing to deal firmly enough with the Persian government, the diplomat in turn believed Curzon to be impatient, with no appreciation of the art of diplomacy. The trouble was that, as viceroy, 'Curzon was too accustomed to getting his own way quickly' (a telling remark considering Curzon's actions towards Persia after 1918).[112] As Hardinge pointed out, he, as a mere minister, could not bully the Persian government the way Curzon could bully Nepal or Afghanistan. Yet, both men agreed that the Home government lacked a coherent policy when it came to Persia, and blamed Salisbury for such vacillation.[113] With the entrance of Lord Lansdowne into the Foreign Office in 1900, however, Curzon finally appeared to gain an ally in his endeavours. Spurred on by the viceroy, in December 1901 the new foreign secretary sent a lengthy despatch to the Persian government stipulating in no uncertain terms the limit to Britain's tolerance regarding a Russian presence in that country.[114] This was followed, in May 1903, by a pronouncement to the House of Lords that reiterated Britain's determination to retain its exclusive position in the Persian Gulf. Any establishment of a naval base or fortified post in that region by another power, declared Lansdowne, would be 'a very grave menace to British interests, and... we should certainly resist it with all means at our disposal'.[115] At last it appeared that Britain was prepared to